One half of them were engaged by army artillery at Sakteshgarh railway station in Uttar Pradesh. Those who managed to escape were rounded up by the 21st Mechanized Infantry Regiment. The others engaged with the artillery and troops of the 20th Infantry Brigade, during which thirty-five soldiers from both sides were killed. There were five more smaller mutinies in different parts of India. A total of fifty-five mutineers were killed and 2,606 rounded up.

Some senior retired army officers were of the view that the mutinies could have been prevented had the men been fully informed about the developments in Punjab. Lt Gen. Harbaksh Singh felt that to counter the soldiers' belief that that their villages were under attack, the Regimental Centre should have sent small parties of Sikh soldiers under the command of officers to Punjab to see for themselves what was actually happening on the ground and report it back to their colleagues. Lt Gen. S.K. Sinha said he would squarely blame the officer corps for the mutinies because they were apparently ignorant of what their men were thinking. [28]

Unfounded apprehension

One major justification for the progressively harsher and increasingly destructive measures adopted by the army as Operation Blue Star became prolonged was the apprehension that a mass upsurge of Sikhs from the rural areas might head towards the Golden Temple. Contrast this with the actual on-the-ground experience of *Indian Express* reporter Sanjay Suri on 7 June, the day the death of Bhindranwale and destruction of the Akal Takht became public knowledge. That day, Sanjay Suri did not visit any ordinary place but went straight to Bhindranwale's ancestral home in Rode village in Faridkot district.

Soon after AIR announced the news of Bhindranwale's death, Suri wanted to personally check on rumours about a massive uprising in Rode village. While asking for directions on his way to Rode, a young Sikh man offered to ferry him on the carrier of his bicycle and dropped him close to Bhindranwale's home. Suri saw a large number of Sikhs standing quietly outside. There wasn't a